

WOMEN OF industry

In 1832, men's wages in American cotton factories exceeded women's wages by 58%

THE INDUSTRIAL REVOLUTION

From the mid-18th to the mid-19th century, economic and industrial production changed dramatically. Termed the Industrial Revolution, it began in the United Kingdom, and other countries in Western Europe and North America soon followed. Many areas of manufacturing, particularly textiles, became mechanized and shifted toward factory-based production. New techniques made iron and steel cheaper and stronger, while steam (fueled by coal and water) powered machines and engines. Improved farming systems meant that agriculture required less labor, allowing people to move from rural to urban areas. Although the Industrial Revolution would eventually lead to increases in income and life expectancy in the 20th century, it also caused significant social dislocation.

Benefits for women

Historians disagree on how beneficial the Industrial Revolution was to women. Some argue that overall women gained from industrialization, as it boosted their economic independence by increasing their paid labor participation outside of the home. Others are more pessimistic; they point out that before the Industrial Revolution men and women worked together in a family's economic activity, be it running a farm or a "cottage industry" (small-scale, home-based manufacturing, such as spinning or weaving). Once manufacturing

◀ Weaving revolution

Patented in 1770, the spinning jenny was a vast improvement upon the spinning wheel. The jenny, which could do the work of eight traditional wheels, could be operated by one person, leading to a huge increase in productivity.

